

Growing in Freedom

Learning Together

Juan Manuel Ferrera Diaz

2025

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Crece en Libertad

Crecer en Libertad

Aprendiendo juntos

Juan Manuel Ferrera Díaz

Crece en Libertad: *Aprende juntos*

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*Para todos los niños y niñas
que crecen en libertad,

y para las familias valientes
que eligen caminar
este sendero menos transitado.*

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Foreword

/By Anna/

Co-founder of Crecer en Libertad, along with Marta and the author

Traditional schooling is under more question every year, and free-range parenting stands there as an alternative worth looking at. This book is an invitation to think again about how we raise and teach children, with the child's curiosity and independence as the ground everything else stands on.

So what is free-range parenting? It's rejecting the idea that learning has to be structured and controlled from outside. Children learn on their own—exploring, asking, getting it wrong, trying again—as long as we don't interrupt them. They learn to walk without a curriculum. They learn to talk without formal lessons. Why do we think reading, writing, or making sense of the world needs something different?

This movement goes back a long way. John Holt put it into words in the sixties when he watched school kill the love of learning children are born with. Maria Montessori before him. Ivan Illich after. It isn't new. It's a rediscovery of the way we always learned before standardized classrooms existed.

In here you'll find families who took the leap. Hadrián learned to read at his own pace—no pressure, no shame, no comparisons. Patricia watched her son Marcos build his own curriculum at nine, following what he cared about. Marta and Julio saw their children come alive once they stopped forcing them into ready-made shapes. Their stories will show you it can

be done, and that you aren't the only one.

You'll find practical things too: how to give a day shape without a timetable, what to do when your child says "I'm bored" at ten in the morning, how to answer when your mother asks in that voice, "and what if he never learns math?" Activities that feed play and exploration, ways to keep curiosity alive without smothering it, ways to build a rich house without turning it into a classroom.

The school system deserves to be questioned. It was built to turn out obedient workers for the Industrial Revolution, not free thinkers for the twenty-first century. We'll look at its limits, at what it fails to do, at why more families every year go looking for something else. But this isn't a book for complaining. It's a book for doing.

Rethink how you raise and teach. Take your child as he is instead of shaping him to somebody else's expectations. Build a path where freedom and respect are the rule and not the exception. Every child deserves to grow up somewhere that makes room for what he could become instead of cutting it down.

Preface

This book came out of a question that has followed me as a father since the first day: how do I walk alongside my children while they learn without hemming them in, without pressing them into a shape that isn't theirs?

When my eldest was five, the moment arrived when society expected me to enroll him in school. I remember the sleepless nights, the endless conversations, the doubts that jumped me. Was I being irresponsible? Was I denying him chances other kids would get? What would our families say, our friends, our neighbors?

Deciding not to send our children to school wasn't done lightly. It came after months of reading everything about alternative education I could get my hands on, and after finding other families who had gone this way before us. I found Ivan Illich, John Holt, John Taylor Gatto, and their words landed on something I had been feeling and hadn't found the words for: the learning that matters happens in freedom, not under pressure.

But it was watching my own children, more than any book, that settled it. I saw them learn to walk without walking lessons, to talk without language classes, to go at the world with a hunger no curriculum could have designed. So why would reading, or math, or anything else be different?

This book comes out of years of doing it, of getting it wrong and getting it right. It isn't meant to be the last word. Every family is its own thing, and what worked for us may not be your answer.

What I do hope is that these pages are company and support for families who, like ours, feel the pull to do it another way. For anyone facing the same doubts I faced, the same pressure, the same fear. I want them to know they aren't alone, that there's a growing number of families on this road who have found real satisfaction in it, hard as it can be.

While I was writing I got to talk with dozens of home-educating families and listen to what worked and what didn't. I gathered the research that backs up what many of us have lived: that children are built to learn, that curiosity is the strongest engine there is, that respect and trust sit under any real education.

I've run into my own contradictions too. There were times I doubted, times I asked myself whether I was making a mistake. Times the pressure from outside was almost too much. But every time I looked at my children—sure of themselves, inventive, hungry to learn—I knew we were on the right road for our family.

This preface wouldn't be complete without Anna and Marta, who founded *Crece en Libertad* with me. Our story together started at ALE, the Free Education Association, Spain's largest home-education network, where we met plenty of families looking for something other than school. In time we realized what we wanted went further than homeschooling.

What we cared about was unschooling: the idea that learning can happen on its own, with no curriculum laid over it, no rigid hours, no school transplanted into the living room. We wanted a place where families could try out that more radical version, one that trusts children to run their own learning.

Leaving ALE and starting our own community, *Crece en Libertad*, was hard and it was necessary. It wasn't a rejection of ALE or of the families we met there, many of whom are still close friends. It was a search for something that matched what we actually believed. We wanted a place where unschooling wasn't treated as the far end of the spectrum but as a

legitimate way to raise and teach a child.

Anna and Marta have carried this project. What they saw, and their gift for making a community out of scattered people, is why *Crece en Libertad* is now a reference point for unschooling families in our part of the world. Anna's foreword shows what comes out of families pulling together around a shared idea, not in theory but day after day.

My thanks as well to every family who shared what they've lived for this book, to the researchers whose work lit up this field, and above all to my sons, who have been my real teachers.

/Crece en Libertad/—growing in freedom—isn't only the title of this book. It's a way of living, a bet on trusting our children and what they can do on their own. It's also an invitation to question what's settled, to imagine an education that is more human, more respectful, closer to what children actually need.

I hope you find in these pages some inspiration and some company for your own road, whatever shape it takes.

With gratitude and hope,

Juan Manuel Ferrera Díaz

Spring 2025

Acknowledgments

My thanks to every family who shares its road and what it has learned, and to everyone who believes in a future where each child gets to learn and grow in his own way. Thank you to the families brave enough to break with the mold and look for another way to educate their children, and to share their stories, their hard patches and their wins. What they've done is a source of encouragement for anybody looking for a gentler, more human way to raise a child.

To the teachers and thinkers who lit this road, with research and ideas that push back against the settled rules, thank you for the work of changing what we understand teaching and learning to be. I'm grateful in particular to everyone who has argued with me, offering other angles on raising and teaching children. Those arguments built a community where different views are welcome and every voice counts.

The support networks that grew up around this movement deserve their own mention. They give families a warm place to swap resources, advice and friendship. Without them plenty of us would have felt cut off, second-guessing every decision on our own. Their work matters for changing how alternative education is seen.

The researchers and the people who gather resources—the ones who have spent years documenting and analyzing this movement—have been essential. Their work is the solid ground the rest of this stands on. Thank you for giving us evidence and not only encouragement.

And to our children, our real teachers on this road. Their curiosity, their delight and their straightness keep showing us that learning doesn't stop at a classroom door. It happens everywhere: in the questions they ask on waking, in the hours they lose in projects nobody assigned them, in the way they solve problems nobody taught them to solve. Thank you to every one of you—readers, families, teachers—for opening up and sharing what you think about raising children, about love, and about learning. Together we're building a future where our children's education and their well-being come first, with compassion, understanding and freedom.

Foundations: Understanding Free-Range Parenting

1. An Introduction to Free-Range Parenting

It was an ordinary morning when my four-year-old asked me, “Dad, why is the sky blue?” Instead of giving him a quick answer or telling him we’d look it up later, we sat down together. What started as a question about the color of the sky turned into two hours on light, prisms, rainbows, and why sunsets are red. He ran the whole conversation. I went along for the ride.

That taught me something I’ve never let go of: children don’t need us to “teach” them how to learn. They already know. What they need is room to explore, time to go deep into whatever has them, and adults who trust what they can do on their own.

That’s what free-range parenting is.

What Free-Range Parenting Means

Free-range parenting rejects the idea that learning has to be structured and controlled. When we let children explore at their own speed, without the fences of formal schooling, something happens: they actually learn. They don’t memorize for a test—they find things out because they want to know.

Those of us who take this road aren’t instructors. We’re guides, people going along with them. We make a place where a child’s curiosity counts for more than any set curriculum, where what he starts on his own matters more than whether he does as he’s told.

Children are learning from the day they're born. They watch, they touch, they try, they get involved. Play isn't "free time" before the "real work"—play is where everything important happens. What interests them takes them to what they need to know. Education stops being something separate from living and becomes the living itself.

A Short History of Alternative Education

We aren't inventing anything. John Dewey and Maria Montessori argued a century ago for an education built on real experience instead of memorizing, and for treating a child as a person rather than an empty container. The sixties and seventies brought the counterculture, and with it a harder question: what if learning can happen without schools at all?

Today alternative education is growing everywhere. In the United States millions of families homeschool—not on a whim, but because the standard system doesn't answer what their children actually need. They want to teach according to what they believe, to build places where inventiveness counts for more than obedience and curiosity for more than a grade.

And it isn't only homeschooling. Unschooling goes further: no curriculum at all, complete trust in the child. Sudbury schools run as democracies where the children vote on the rules. Waldorf runs art and the natural world through everything. They all share the same two things: self-directed learning and full respect for the individual child.

The best part of this movement isn't the philosophies. It's the communities. Families who find each other, air their doubts, celebrate the wins, and hold each other up when the world tells them they're mad. Raising children this way is easier when you aren't doing it alone.

Why a Child's Independence Matters

When we let our children decide—what to study, when, how—something basic shifts. They don't only gain independence. They build the kind of

confidence that comes from solving a problem yourself, not from being told “well done” every five minutes. The relationship stops being top-down and goes level: we work together, learn together, grow together.

Independence shapes who a child is. A child who chooses what to learn learns something deeper: he learns who he is. He works out what actually interests him, not what he's supposed to be interested in. He finds his own limits instead of having them handed to him. He feels like the owner of his life because, in large part, he is.

I know a family in Galicia, in northern Spain, whose son came alive after leaving school in ways his parents never expected. Not because he was “gifted”—because he could follow what he cared about without being interrupted every forty minutes. Children raised this way tend to be more adaptable (they have no script to follow), more talkative (nobody trained them to sit still and be quiet), more able to read other people (they had time to work out their own feelings first).

Is it easy? No. You'll take criticism. “And what if he fails?” “Aren't you sheltering him?” “What happens when he has to follow rules?” But once you find other families who get it, who had the same doubts and came out the other side, everything changes.

Free-range parenting isn't a method. It's a road—messy at times, always human, and full of love. We put how a child is doing ahead of what he scores, and self-knowledge ahead of a syllabus. And when we do it together, sharing what we have and holding each other up, we don't only help our children. We help ourselves remember what growing up is actually for.

You might be wondering: “This all sounds lovely, but is there anything behind it? Is it just an idealistic philosophy, or is there research?” That's exactly what the next chapter is about: the theory and the evidence under this way of teaching. You'll find that free-range parenting isn't an experiment. It's a return to how humans learned for thousands of years.

2. The History and Theory of Alternative Education

Sofia is seven and has never set foot in a classroom. When I ask her what she did yesterday, her eyes light up and she tells me she spent the whole afternoon watching ants in the garden. “Did you know they talk with their antennas?” Then she pulled out the encyclopedia, looked things up online, and ended the day drawing a full ant colony with tunnels and chambers. Nobody told her to study insects. Nobody assigned her a “project.” Like millions of children before her, she followed what she wanted to know.

That scene, repeated in thousands of homes where families teach outside the system, raises a question: what would happen if we trusted that pull to learn a little more? What if, instead of laying a rigid curriculum over a child, we went along with what already interests him?

How Natural Learning Works

Children don't need us to teach them how to learn. They already know—they've been doing it since the day they were born. Natural learning simply trusts that. We let them explore, discover at their own pace, and follow what grabs them instead of what the textbook says comes next.

Think about it: when a child learns to talk, nobody sits him down for grammar lessons. He listens, tries, gets it wrong, adjusts. He learns by playing, by talking, by living. Why would math, or history, or science work any

differently?

Alternative education takes a child's real interests seriously. If he's mad about dinosaurs, he'll learn geology, biology, history and math—all through his obsession with extinct animals. Skills grow on their own because they're attached to something that matters to him. Ideas connect naturally when the child is the one connecting them instead of being handed the connection.

The Psychology of Learning: How Children Learn

Alison Gopnik, a cognitive scientist at Berkeley, compares small children to scientists running experiments. It isn't a metaphor—they're literally using statistical inference to work out how the world behaves. A baby throws his spoon on the floor a hundred times not to annoy you but to test a hypothesis about gravity, cause and effect, and the sounds things make.

Developmental psychology confirms what any observant parent already knows: children are learning machines. But they don't learn by memorizing lists. They learn by exploring, touching, trying, watching. They learn best when they feel safe, when the people around them are warm, when nobody is grading them every hour.

Being with other people matters enormously—but not thirty children facing a blackboard in silence. Children learn socially by talking, playing, settling real arguments, working together on something they care about. They build self-control not because we teach a lesson on it but because real life demands it: waiting your turn in a game you actually want to play teaches more patience than a thousand lectures.

What's Wrong with the School System

The school system rewards obedience over curiosity. Everyone learns the same thing, at the same time, the same way. If your child doesn't fit that one shape, the system labels him as behind—it never asks whether the shape is

the problem.

“A culture of hard work” sounds fine in the abstract. In practice it means: if you don't learn the way I teach, that's on you. A child's curiosity withers under the steady weight of grades, comparisons and assessments. The message underneath is that learning isn't finding things out. It's complying.

Learning by doing barely exists. Children memorize formulas and can't work out the change in a shop. They study photosynthesis in a book and never plant a seed. Theory cut loose from life. The result is that they can't use any of what they “learned.”

The whole structure strips out independence. Students can't make decisions about their own learning. Sit down. Be quiet. Do this. Don't do that. Inventiveness and any wish to learn for its own sake go out the window. Alternative education starts from the opposite place: the child can choose his own road, and should.

Then there's the socialization everyone defends. Thirty children of the same age facing a blackboard in silence isn't socializing—it's training in obedience. Real collaboration happens when children work together on something they care about, solve real problems, and learn from each other instead of competing for a mark.

Alternative education isn't perfect. But at least it starts from an honest premise: children learn better when the learning means something, when it connects to what they care about, when it isn't an exercise in submission dressed up as “preparation for life.”

John Taylor Gatto taught for thirty years in New York and was named Teacher of the Year. In *Dumbing Us Down* he lists what school does to children:

- It confuses them. It hands over an incoherent pile of information the child has to memorize while he's there. Apart from the tests, the programming works like television: it fills up the children's “free”

time. They listen and hear something only to forget it again.

- It teaches them to accept their place in a class.
- It makes them indifferent.
- It makes them emotionally dependent.
- It makes them intellectually dependent.
- It gives them a self-regard that needs constant confirmation from experts.
- It makes clear they can hide nothing, because they are watched all the time.

Gatto isn't speaking from ignorance. He's speaking from thirty years inside. And what he describes isn't the fault of individual teachers, plenty of whom work with real devotion. It's the structure itself, designed more than a century ago for a world that no longer exists.

The good news is that we aren't stuck with it. Thousands of families around the world show every day that there are workable, respectful alternatives. Free-range parenting offers a road where children do well without these artificial walls.

But here's the problem: you already knew all this. Somewhere underneath, you felt it. The theory convinced you, the science backed you up, the criticism of the system told you that you weren't imagining it. Good.

Now comes the hard part. It's ten in the morning on a Tuesday. Your five-year-old is "bored." Your mother-in-law is coming for lunch. The neighbor just asked which school he goes to. Your partner is giving you the look that says, *are we sure about this?*

Theory doesn't save you in that moment. You need something concrete. Real tools. A plan for when it all feels like chaos and you wonder whether you're wrecking your child's future.

That's what comes next.

Practice: Living Free-Range Parenting

3. Everyday Strategies and Tools

John Taylor Gatto took apart our illusions about school. *Dumbing Us Down* was the shout that woke up a whole generation of parents. When I first read it I was angry—angry at the years I'd spent inside a system he described so plainly. But I was also relieved. I wasn't mad. The system really was built to confuse, to breed dependence, to smother curiosity.

Gatto taught us to see what was wrong. He gave us the words for it. But Gatto wrote from the trench, as a teacher stuck inside the thing, shouting to be heard.

This book is what comes after. It's the *so now what?* that follows waking up. If Gatto showed you the chains, this book is about living without them.

It isn't theory anymore. It's ten in the morning on a Tuesday. It's your child saying he's bored. It's building something real where before there was only the complaint.

The strategies here aren't abstract or complicated. They're concrete things, tried by thousands of families, that you can start tomorrow. From turning play into deep learning to making a house that invites exploration, they'll help you go along with your children while they find things out.

The best part is that none of it needs a teaching degree. It needs something worth more: your presence, and your trust in your children.

What Play Is For

Play is where the real learning happens. Watch any child at play: he's exploring, experimenting, dealing with the world in ways no curriculum could set out. The research keeps saying the same thing—children learn best when they're free to play. They build self-control, invention and social skill without anybody giving them a lesson in any of it.

Free play is self-directed learning. Children follow their own interests at their own pace. There's no artificial line between “play time” and “school work”—it's all learning when it comes from them.

Playing, children build their bodies and their minds. They learn to get along, to negotiate who plays what, to settle arguments. Nobody teaches them these things directly—they find them out in the act, where they actually matter. Play is the education, not a break from it.

Make a house where play is normal, not a reward for finishing something else. Take it seriously. Your child doesn't need more enriching activities. He needs unclaimed time.

Feeding Curiosity

Curiosity is the thing to protect. The main way to do it is to build a place that provokes it: materials within reach, room to explore without being stopped, and questions that open rather than close. When children are encouraged to ask and to go find their own answers, they get more independent and they start seeing learning as something that never really finishes.

Hands-on experience—getting outside, simple experiments, making things—feeds curiosity on its own. Families keep saying the same thing: this kind of time makes them closer and lets each child find his own pace. Parents should show real wonder themselves. That's how a child learns that finding things out never stops.

Building a House Worth Exploring

A learning environment should be full of things to do. Enough physical room, a range of resources—books, materials, tools—and adults who are there without getting in the way. The essential part is that the child feels safe enough to try and to fail. A place with natural things in it, art materials and real tools multiplies the ways a child can get at the world.

These places should bend to different paces and different ways of working, supporting a child in directing himself and making his own decisions. Parents matter here—not to control, but to take a child's interests and feelings seriously. It also helps to make room for other children and for working together. Getting out into the world—outdoors, museums, an afternoon with somebody who's good at something—puts all of it in a real setting.

From Theory to Real Life: My Road with Arjuna and Nitai

All of this—the play, the curiosity, the rich surroundings—sounds lovely in theory. But what does it actually look like? Let me tell you what happened to us.

I arrived in Spain from Australia a widower, with two small children—Arjuna was five, Nitai three and a half. I had just lost my wife. I was wrecked, frightened, and now their whole education was on me, in a country where they didn't speak a word of the language.

I had no teaching plan. No curriculum. I had two children who needed a language to survive in their new world.

1. The game with the colored sticks

Want to know how I taught them Spanish? With colored sticks hidden in my hands. I'd close my fist around one—red, blue, green, yellow. I'd open my hand fast and they had to shout the color in Spanish before I closed it again. Whoever said it first got a point.

It wasn't a certified Montessori method. It was a game I made up

out of desperation. But it worked. In three months they spoke fluently. Why? Because it was pure play—competition, laughing, being together. There was no language class. There were two brothers racing to shout “yellow!” before the other one.

2. The rules we made up together

Cards came next. But we didn't play games with fixed rules. We invented the rules as we went. Somebody would put down a card and say, “this one counts double if it's red.” Somebody else would add, “but face cards cancel doubles.” The rules changed every hand.

What were they learning? Negotiation. Logic. That rules aren't handed down from heaven—they're agreements between people. That you can change them if everybody agrees. Years later, when Arjuna had a falling-out with a friend, he didn't come to me in tears. He came with proposals: “Dad, what if we did this instead of that?” And Nitai learned to sit between friends who were arguing and remind them they could make new rules instead of fighting over the old ones.

3. Wrestling with Dad

We fought. Real wrestling, on the floor, pushing and shoving. But there were unwritten rules that showed up on their own: no hitting the face, stop when somebody says stop, help the other one up when it's over.

Those wrestling rules turned into rules for living. They learned that being strong comes with responsibility. That you can go at each other hard and still respect the other person. That “stop” means stop, every time. No lesson on respect would have taught that. They learned it in their bodies, sweating on the living room floor.

4. The packet of cigarettes

When they were older, I put a packet of cigarettes on a piece of fur-

niture within their reach. There were still a few inside. I told them: this is here for whoever wants to smoke.

Months later the packet was untouched. I asked them whether they didn't want to try. They looked at me as though I'd lost my mind. "Dad, are you all right in the head?"

I never lectured them about tobacco. I never showed them photographs of blackened lungs. I trusted that if they were free to choose without pressure, they'd choose well. And they did.

The real test came later, in the street. Arjuna started spending time with lads a bit older than him. They offered him cigarettes. They offered him other things. He said no. They pushed. He said no again. They pushed harder.

Until one day, fed up, he came out with it: "I don't do it because I don't want to. Because my father lets me."

They stood there. "What do you mean, he lets you? If my dad saw me doing this he'd kill me." "Mine would ground me for a month." "I don't even tell mine about this stuff"

Arjuna had found something on his own that I never spelled out: when you have permission, you don't need to rebel. Rebellion loses its appeal when there's nothing to rebel against. He was choosing not to smoke because it was his choice, not because he was defying me.

5. The sweet shop

With sweets I did the opposite. I took them to a candy shop and told them to buy whatever they wanted. They each filled a bag—gummies, gum, chocolate, the lot. They stuffed themselves for hours.

They got stomach ache. They didn't want sweets for weeks. After that, when there were dried figs, dates and ripe fruit in the house,

that was enough. I never had to ban anything. They ran into the consequences themselves and adjusted.

6. The kitchen timer

When they hit their teens, when they stop talking to you and most of the conversation is contradicting you, I found a trick for the serious subjects.

I'd set a kitchen timer for three or five minutes. "It's your turn. While it's your turn I don't speak. I don't interrupt. I don't argue back. I only listen." When it rang, it was my turn. Same rules.

For the first time in weeks, they listened to me. Why? Because they knew I had listened to them—actually listened, without cutting in. I remember one conversation with Nitai where he was certain I never understood him. The timer gave him three minutes to say exactly what he felt. When his turn ended and he'd heard mine, he went quiet for a moment and then said, "Huh. I hadn't thought of it that way." Mutual respect isn't preached. It's practiced.

7. Reverse psychology and trust

Reverse psychology works beautifully once you understand the principle: they often already know whether something is good or bad for them. What they need is the feeling that the decision is theirs.

I never made them eat. But I also didn't cook them special meals or give in to their whims, except on rare occasions. If they didn't want what was on the table, they didn't eat. Nobody starved. They learned to listen to their own bodies.

8. When we tried ordinary school

There was a stretch when we decided to try regular school. I wanted them to have the experience and make up their own minds. But I wasn't going to let the system flatten them.

I went to see the head. “My sons aren’t going to take homework home.”

He looked at me as though I’d spoken to him in another language. “But... all the children have homework. It’s part of the curriculum.”

“I understand. But not mine. They can do all the work in class. When they leave the school, their time is theirs.”

He agreed, though he clearly thought I was mad. Arjuna and Nitai’s classmates couldn’t believe it. “You’re so lucky. I’m doing homework every afternoon and you’re out playing.”

It wasn’t luck. It was a decision not to let school take over every hour of their lives.

I told him something else he found even stranger: “Don’t worry about their marks. Marks don’t mean my sons are more or less clever. They’re numbers on a piece of paper.”

The boys heard that. They stopped panicking about exams. They learned because something interested them, not because they needed a ten out of ten.

Then there was the swearing. At school, as at every school, children pick up words their parents would rather not hear. Other parents panicked: “My son swore! What do I do?”

I didn’t ban it. I set one simple rule: “Not in the house. Outside the house, you decide.”

Why? Because banning it outright was pointless—they’d say the words anyway, just out of earshot. But I didn’t want them normal in our house either. Home was where we were decent to each other.

What happened was interesting. When there’s no absolute ban, no drama and no punishment, swearing loses its power. They swore in the schoolyard, like every child. At home they kept to the agreement.

Not out of fear, but because they understood the deal.

Years later Nitai said to me: “Dad, I worked out that swearing is only useful when you’re furious and something has to come out. The rest of the time it sounds stupid.” He got there on his own, with no sermon from me.

And on Mondays they didn’t go to school. Ever.

In Spain you can miss up to four days a month with a note from the parent, no questions asked. So every Monday I wrote one: “Absent for reasons beyond our control.” That was that.

Why Mondays? Because they needed a day to recover from the week before, to do things that actually mattered to them, to remember that school wasn’t their whole life. It was one part of it, and not the most important.

Their classmates asked: “Why are you always off on Mondays?” And they answered: “Because we can.”

In the end they decided ordinary school wasn’t for them. They’d seen both worlds and chose the freedom. But the experience taught them something worth having: you can be inside the system without letting the system define you.

9. Learning from the real world

While other children learned about “the post” from a textbook with drawings of smiling postmen, I took Arjuna and Nitai to the post office. They watched the whole real process: weighing a letter, choosing the right stamp, filling in the form, seeing it sorted and dropped in the sack. They talked to the staff and asked questions. “Where does this letter go?” “How long does it take to reach Australia?”

It wasn’t an educational activity. It was life. And they learned more in twenty minutes at the post office than in a week of lessons on the

postal system.

Math went the same way. One day we needed to paint a room. I explained that to know how much paint to buy, we had to work out the area of the walls.

I didn't hand them a worksheet of length-times-width problems. We got out a tape measure. They measured the walls. They did the sums. We went to the shop. The man told us how much paint we needed based on the square meters they'd calculated. We bought exactly that. We painted the room.

Did they learn to calculate area? Yes. Did they notice they were “doing math”? Barely. To them they were solving a real problem: how much paint do we need?

That's the difference between abstract learning and learning in context. At school you calculate the area of imaginary rectangles on a sheet of paper. In life you calculate area because you need to paint your room. One is an exercise. The other is living.

But there's something deeper here, and it's what I'd call learning across the board. Painting that room wasn't only math. It was physics (how paint sticks, how to cover evenly). Chemistry (why some colors need more coats). Economics (a budget, comparing prices at the shop). Planning (how long it would take, which wall first). Teamwork (who does what). Patience (waiting for each coat to dry).

At school those would be six subjects, in six rooms, with six teachers, on six different days. In real life they're one job. You can't separate math from physics when you're working out how much paint you need. You can't separate money from planning when you have a limited budget and one weekend.

Everything connects because in real life everything is connected.

Schools chop knowledge into artificial boxes—now math, now science, now language. Life doesn't work that way. In life you solve complicated problems that pull on several kinds of knowledge at once.

My sons never had to ask what any of it was for, because they were always learning things that were for something they could see.

And this goes further still when a child gets obsessed with something. Children have that wonderful capacity to sink completely into whatever fascinates them. A child obsessed with firefighters doesn't only learn about firefighters. He learns about trucks (mechanics, engineering), equipment (materials, technology), water (pressure, how fluids behave), fire (combustion), maps (geography, finding your way), numbers (how many firefighters, how many ladders, how fast they get there), history (what firefighters were like a hundred years ago), even math (the angle of a ladder, the flow of water).

At school they'd say, "that's enough about firefighters, now it's geography." But that obsession *is* the door into geography, into math, into everything. When you follow a child's deep interest, that interest carries him into every field there is. You don't have to teach geography—it turns up on its own when he's looking at maps of fire stations in different cities.

The difference is that he learns geography because he cares, because it's attached to something he loves, not because it's next on the timetable.

I took them to friends of mine who were good at things—a working musician, a potter, a programmer, a gardener. Not for lessons. Just to be there while these people worked. They watched, they asked, sometimes they helped. They saw what real work looks like, not the tidy version in textbooks.

Live music was one of the big ones. Not children's concerts with

children's songs—real concerts, with musicians playing music they loved. Watching somebody disappear into an instrument, feeling the sound in your chest, standing among other people struck by the same thing. You can't teach that. You can only be there for it.

And there were the gatherings with other families teaching outside the system. There they learned something school would never have taught them: how to get on with people of every age. Babies, small children, teenagers, adults, old people—all together, talking, playing, learning from each other.

At school you spend year after year shut in with children born within months of you, as though age were the only thing that mattered for friendship or for learning. It's artificial. In real life your best teachers and friends can be five years old or fifty. Arjuna and Nitai found that out early.

10. The secret: don't explain so much

After all these stories you might expect me to say, *and this is how you should explain each thing to your child*. My experience taught me the opposite.

You don't have to explain that much. They pick it up.

Your job isn't to be a constant transmitter of wisdom. Your job is to put good things in their path—experiences, interesting people, and above all books.

If you get your child to love reading, you've done half of it. Reading brings so much of what parents obsess about teaching: comprehension, spelling, vocabulary, knowing how the world works, understanding other people, thinking straight. It's all in books.

You don't need to sit down and explain spelling rules. Give him books he can't put down and he'll absorb spelling. You don't need to give history lessons—give him a good historical novel and he'll learn more

than in a year of class.

Children learn on their own when they can get at things that interest them. Not because they're made to, but because from small they see that books in this house are treasure, not homework. Reading becomes a pleasure instead of a chore.

And through that they pick up everything they need, without our teaching it.

Children are sponges. They absorb what's around them. Your job isn't to fill their heads with explanations. It's to surround them with things worth absorbing.

People sometimes ask me: "How come your sons turned out so well brought up?"

My answer throws them: "Because I didn't bring them up."

It's useless trying to instill anything. They do what they see you do. And not even always—they have their own judgment. But if you're decent, they'll be decent without being told. If you read, they'll read. If you treat people with respect, they'll learn respect, not because you explained it but because they lived in it.

You can't teach values with sermons. Values are absorbed by watching you live. A father shouting "don't shout!" is teaching shouting. A father saying "read more" while watching television is teaching television.

Your children watch you all the time. They don't listen to your words so much as watch what you do. They learn more from how you handle it when something goes wrong than from any speech about managing your feelings. They learn generosity from whether you share or keep, not from a lesson on being generous.

That's why I say I didn't bring them up. I lived a certain way in front

of them, and they took what fitted who they are.

11. The one rule

My aim was always this: that my sons could never say to me, *you made me do this*. Trust their judgment, and that's how they get good judgment. Treat their decisions with respect, and they learn to make decisions worth respecting.

Did I make mistakes? Thousands. Were there chaotic days when I questioned all of it? Whole weeks. Did it work? Today Arjuna and Nitai are young men who think for themselves, who question authority when it needs questioning, who respect other people because they were respected.

You don't need a degree in education. You don't need a perfect curriculum. You need invention, presence, and the nerve to trust your children—even when, especially when, you don't know exactly what's going to happen.

These are my stories. My road with Arjuna and Nitai. But I'm not unique, or special, or extraordinary.

Over the years I've met dozens of families who made similar decisions—each with their own style, their own difficulties, their own wins. Some of them turn up in these pages: Patricia, who took on her whole family; Marta and Julio with their son Hadrián, who learned to read at his own pace; whole communities in Galicia and elsewhere who hold each other up.

The Essentials: Your Toolbox

I remember the night I found Ivan Illich's *Deschooling Society*. It was two in the morning, my son was asleep, and I was frozen with the fear that I was wrecking his future by keeping him out of school. That book didn't only answer my doubts—it gave me the words for what I already felt. It made me

part of something bigger, a movement with decades of history and serious thinking behind it.

That's what the right resources do: you find out you aren't inventing anything, you're joining a conversation that's been going on for generations. Every book, every community, every activity here has pulled some family out of the doubt that freezes you. These aren't “resources.” They're lines thrown by people who crossed this water before you.

Books Worth Reading

A good shelf matters when children run their own learning. Here's a selection on respectful parenting, alternative education and natural learning. Each one is here because it changed something for a real family:

- ***Crianza tranquila* (Calm Parenting)** by Laura Gutman: For parents who need something practical right now. On why a child's feelings have to be taken seriously, with concrete everyday examples.
- ***Raising Our Children, Raising Ourselves*** by Naomi Aldort: For the bad moments. Tested ways to raise children in mutual respect, especially useful when you can feel your patience going.
- ***Deschooling Society*** by Ivan Illich: The book that changed the global conversation about education. It questions schooling down to the roots and points to self-directed, community learning. Essential for understanding the deep *why*.
- ***Summerhill*** by A.S. Neill: Built on decades of real experience at Summerhill, the most famous free school in the world. It argues for freedom in education with examples of children who came alive without being forced.
- ***Kiss Me! (Bésame mucho)*** by Carlos González: Scientific and warm at once. On the bond between parents and children, backed by research—good for parents who want evidence as well as instinct.

- ***How Children Fail*** by John Holt: The pioneer of unschooling sets down what he saw as a teacher. He takes apart the limits of the school system with compassion and clarity, and shows alternatives that work.
- ***I Was Never Sent to School (Yo nunca fui a la escuela)*** by André Stern: An autobiography showing you can grow up without schooling and become a whole, inventive, capable adult. A comfort on the days you wonder whether you're doing the right thing.

Communities and Support

One of the most important things you'll learn on this road: you aren't alone. Thousands of families have chosen this, and plenty of them are waiting to help you. Being part of a community can be the difference between feeling cut off and feeling part of something.

Some of the most active networks, most of them Spanish, though every country has its equivalent:

- /Asociación por la Libre Educación (ALE)/: Spain's largest home-education network. Legal advice, national events, and links to local groups. The right place to start and to understand where you stand legally.
- /OLEA (Organización de Libre Educación Alternativa)/: Focused on non-formal education. Workshops, camps and events where the children play while the parents learn and hold each other up.
- /Xarxa d'Educació Lliure (XELL)/: If you live in Catalonia, this is yours. A grouping of free-education projects with a radical unschooling bent, where the families most committed to children's independence find their people.
- *Creixer en Llibertat*: Our own community, started out of a wish to go further into unschooling than homeschooling goes. Monthly meet-

ings, busy group chats, and a shared library.

- *Forums and social media groups*: You'll find groups for homeschooling and unschooling in every language. Places where you can ask a question at three in the morning when the doubts jump you, and somebody who has been through the same thing will be awake.

Things to Do at Home

Doing things keeps children interested. Some ideas:

- */A small vegetable patch/*: Gardening teaches botany and looking after the ground under your feet, and puts a child in touch with the natural world.
- *Insect shelters*: Small refuges out of scrap materials that draw insects in and teach how an ecosystem holds together.
- */Simple experiments/*:
 - *A baking soda volcano*: Chemical reactions, and fun.
 - *Germinating seeds*: How a plant starts and how its life runs.
- *Art and making*: Scrap materials and creative projects.
- *Getting outside*: Trips into the country, collecting samples, watching what's there. Finding leaves and identifying them teaches plenty and costs nothing.
- *Reading together*: A family reading cycle where everyone shares a favorite book and talks about it.
- *Role play and make-believe*: Children take on different characters and build their own stories, which is how they learn to read other people and work together.
- *Board games*: Thinking ahead, strategy, solving something as a group.
- *Cooking together*: Simple recipes teach measuring, food, and doing things for yourself.
- *Acting out stories*: Children perform what they've read, which stretches invention and the ability to speak up.

Putting these into ordinary days doesn't only help children learn. It makes the moments a family actually remembers. They should be understood as chances to feed a love of learning, curiosity, respect for the natural world, and a child growing up whole in a place where he's supported and loved.

Now you have the books, you know the communities, and you have plenty to do. You're ready, right? But let's be honest: the real challenge isn't resources—it's your mother-in-law's look when you tell her your kid isn't going to school. It's the neighbor's awkward question: "And what about socialization?" It's the moment your child asks why his friends go to school and he doesn't.

The next chapter isn't going to lie to you: teaching this way means swimming against the current. But it will also show you the current is changing, that you aren't as alone as you think, and that there are concrete ways to handle criticism without losing your mind or your nerve. Because this is where a lot of families give up—not for lack of resources, but for lack of armor.

4. Handling Social Pressure and Criticism

The first time I told my mother we were going to raise our son without school, there was a ten-second silence that felt like a year. Then came the question: “And what will the neighbors think?” Not *how will he learn?* Not *what does he need?* But *what will people say?*

That's when I understood something: the biggest obstacle here isn't educational, it's social. It isn't convincing your child he can learn without a classroom—children already know that. It's convincing yourself you can hold your ground when your mother-in-law looks at you with pity, when the pediatrician asks whether school wouldn't be better, when your six-year-old comes home crying because his best friend told him he isn't going to learn anything.

This chapter isn't for the faint-hearted. We're going to talk about the looks in the park at ten on a Tuesday morning, the tense family dinners, the tiredness that comes from defending how you raise your children every time somebody asks which school they go to. And we're going to arm you with families who came through it and look back without regret.

The Stigma

Raising children outside the system runs into a hard social stigma. Families who choose it are often looked at with suspicion or plain disapproval,

which shows how deep school runs in how we think. Parents who don't enroll their children get labeled odd, and that pushes them to conform.

The judgment doesn't only come from strangers. Friends and family often voice their worries too, which makes it harder. Social pressure and the fear of being judged by people you love can eat at a parent's confidence and leave both parents and children feeling cut off. Children can end up carrying the weight of being different in a world that rewards fitting in.

Families Who Did It

Plenty of families have stories worth hearing about deciding to teach another way. What comes up again and again is that they were frustrated with school and found something that fit their particular child better. Marta and Julio, the family in Galicia I mentioned, describe how their children grew real appetites for learning, chasing subjects that actually interested them. Their son Hadrián learned to read at his own pace, gladly, because his mother backed him without conditions.

These stories push back against the stigma and give other people something to go on. Sharing what worked shifts how education outside the system is seen. And building support networks, whether local groups or online, lets these families find each other and stop feeling alone.

Dealing with Criticism

Handling criticism is part of this life. Parents field awkward questions and judgments from strangers and from family. What helps is being open about why you chose this, and being willing to explain how you actually go about it.

It's worth developing the skill: getting ready for the common questions, and having answers that reflect what you believe. Concrete examples of what your children have done are more use than arguments.

Here's a practical trick that works beautifully. The real trouble doesn't

come from the government checking up on you. It comes from busybodies who see your children out during school hours and decide it's their business. Neighbors, people at the park, the woman in the supermarket who can't help asking why these children aren't in school.

The way to see them off is simple: tell them you're doing distance learning. Then launch into how it works—the online platform, the flexible hours, the video calls with teachers, the personalized curriculum. Watch them go. They aren't really interested. They only wanted to poke their nose in and feel entitled to an opinion. A boring technical explanation gets rid of them immediately, with no confrontation and no need to defend yourself.

Building a support network matters too. Being around other families in the same position makes you steadier. Groups, in person or online, give you somewhere safe to compare notes. That community tells you your choice isn't only allowed, it's working.

Learning to let criticism go, or to take it on usefully, becomes one of your main tools. And parents can teach their children the same thing, which prepares them for the social pressure they'll meet on their own account.

Five Things People Will Say (and What to Say Back)

Now that we've talked about the pressure, here's the ammunition. Confidence isn't enough on its own—you need facts and arguments that take apart the five objections you'll hear over and over.

These aren't invented. They're the five sentences every home-educating parent has heard hundreds of times, from worried grandmothers to well-meaning pediatricians. The good news is that each one has an answer with evidence behind it.

1. 1. “Your child won’t have social skills”

This is the big one. The king of objections. And it's false.

What the research says: Long-term studies show home-educated

children have social skills equal to or better than schooled children. Why? Because they socialize in real settings—with people of all ages, in genuine situations—not only with thirty children of exactly their own age in an artificial room.

Richard Medlin's work (2013) in the *Journal of Unschooling and Alternative Learning* found that homeschooled children scored significantly higher on social maturity and cooperative behavior than the control group of conventionally schooled children.

Think about it: where do you learn to get on with people? In a room where you're punished for talking and every interaction is controlled and timetabled? Or out in the world, where you go to the market with your mother and haggle with the seller, where you play in the park with children from three to thirteen, where you spend an afternoon with adults who share what you love?

My short answer when somebody asks: “In what other part of adult life will you be shut in with thirty people of exactly your age for six hours a day? School is the /least/ realistic place to learn how to deal with people.”

2. “It only works if you have money”

False. Teaching at home can cost less than school does.

What's true: You don't have to buy a full curriculum, hire tutors, or build a classroom at home. Public libraries are free. Museums have free days. The natural world is the best laboratory there is and doesn't charge admission. There are excellent free resources online.

Families at every income level do this well. Many do it precisely *because* they can't afford private school and won't accept what the public one offers. The resource that matters isn't money. It's time and invention.

A mother I know put it this way: “I used to spend fifty euros a month

on school supplies my son never used. Now we spend twenty on a family membership to the science museum and go every week. He learns more and it costs less.”

3. 3. “You aren’t qualified to teach”

This one assumes educating means teaching in the traditional sense. That's the mistake.

What's true: You don't have to be an expert in everything. You have to make learning possible. Your job isn't to move knowledge from your head into your child's—it's to make a place where curiosity survives and to connect your child with books, people and experiences when his interest calls for them.

Studies show a parent's own level of education has little bearing on how home-educated children do. What counts is commitment, presence, and being willing to learn *alongside* your child.

When my son asked me about astrophysics, I didn't give him a lecture. I got books from the library, we watched Carl Sagan, and we found an amateur astronomer in the neighborhood who let us use his telescope. I learned it with him. That's the model.

4. 4. “The children will end up isolated”

Also false, as long as you build community on purpose.

What's true: Home-educated children often mix with a wider range of people than schooled children do. They join homeschool groups, community sports, music lessons, art workshops, volunteering—and in all of it they're around children and adults of many ages.

Isolation is a risk only if the family doesn't get out. But that's true of families with children in school too. If you never leave the house at weekends, your child will be isolated as well.

The trick is to be deliberate: find local groups, set up a weekly play

day, sign up for things. In my experience my sons had *more* friends than when they were at school, because their friendships weren't limited by age or postcode.

5. 5. "They'll fall behind academically"

This is every parent's private fear. The evidence says the opposite.

What's true: Studies consistently show home-educated children score the same as or higher than schooled children on standardized tests. Rudner's meta-analysis (1999), covering twenty thousand homeschooled children, found they scored between the seventieth and eightieth percentile in every academic area, against a national average of the fiftieth.

Why? Because the learning is fitted to the child. There aren't thirty children competing for a teacher's attention. Nobody waits for the slowest to catch up or rushes because the syllabus has to move. The child works at his pace, goes deep where he's interested, and moves on when he's ready.

But here's the trap: if you measure success only by standardized tests, you've already lost. Real success is a child who *loves* learning, who knows how to find out what he needs, who can think straight. None of that shows up on a multiple-choice paper.

Now you have the answers. Keep them. Practice them in the mirror if you have to. You'll need them.

But remember this: you don't have to convince anybody. You owe your mother-in-law no explanation, nor your pediatrician, nor the neighbor. Your only duty is to your child—and he doesn't need you to win arguments. He needs you to trust him.

Digital Tools

Twenty years ago, teaching at home meant buying expensive encyclopedias and praying the local library had the book you needed. Today, with a connection, you have more knowledge at hand than any nineteenth-century university could have dreamed of.

Technology opened up education in ways John Holt never imagined. It can also swamp you. Which platforms? Which apps are worth it? How do you stop digital learning from turning into staring at a screen?

Here are the tools thousands of families, mine included, have tried. You don't need all of them. You shouldn't use all of them. Take the ones that fit your family and what your children are interested in.

1. Learning Platforms

Khan Academy (khanacademy.org): Free, with courses from basic arithmetic to advanced calculus, plus science, history and programming. Short, clear videos, at your own pace. My son learned trigonometry here, explained better than in any textbook I ever had.

Coursera and edX: Free university courses from MIT, Stanford and Harvard. Good for teenagers who want to go further into something or find out what higher education feels like before committing to it.

****/Duolingo/****: Languages as a game. It isn't perfect and it doesn't replace real immersion, but it's a good place to start. Free and hard to put down.

Scratch (scratch.mit.edu): MIT's platform for learning to program by building games and animations. Good from about seven. They don't only learn code—they learn to think logically and solve problems.

2. Apps Worth Having

For the youngest (three to seven):

- ***Endless Alphabet***: Vocabulary and phonics, visual and interactive. My sons picked up dozens of words playing with it.
- ***DragonBox***: A series that teaches algebra and geometry through games. Children solve equations without noticing they're doing math.

For the middle years (eight to fourteen):

- ***LightBot***: Programming concepts through puzzles. Fun and it works.
- ***Toca Nature***: Build your own natural world and watch the food chains. Good for waking up an interest in biology.

3. Science and Engineering

- ***Robotics kits***: LEGO Mindstorms, Arduino, Raspberry Pi. They cost something up front, but they change how a child learns. Watching your son program a robot to pick things up is learning across the board in action: programming, physics, math and problem-solving in one project.
- ***Science kits***: Look for Thames & Kosmos or National Geographic. Chemistry, physics and biology experiments you can do at the kitchen table.

4. YouTube: the free university

Don't write off YouTube. Picked over with some care, it's remarkable:

- ***Crash Course***: Whole courses in history, science, literature and philosophy, presented by people who care about them.
- ***Kurzgesagt – In a Nutshell***: Animated videos on science and hard ideas, explained so you can follow them.
- ***Veritasium, VSauce, MinutePhysics***: Channels that make science exciting and reachable.

5. The warning that has to go here

All of these are means, not ends. Technology opens the door to knowledge. It doesn't replace curiosity, conversation, or doing the thing yourself.

If your child spends six hours a day in front of a screen doing online courses, you've rebuilt school in digital form. That isn't education in freedom. It's passive consumption with a new name.

Use it alongside the rest. Let him watch a video about volcanoes—then build one with baking soda. Let him learn about birds in an app—then go out with binoculars. The screen opens doors. Real life is where the learning goes deep.

With these, your practical resources are complete. You have the books, the communities, the things to do, and now the technology. You're equipped.

After reading about strategies, criticism and social pressure, I know what you're thinking: *this sounds exhausting. Is it really worth it?* It's the question we ask at three in the morning when we can't sleep, after another tense conversation with our parents, when our child looks up and asks why we're different.

The next chapter is my answer. Not theory—real stories. Families who came out the other side and looked back without regret. Children who grew up without school and are now capable, inventive adults. Because you need to know this isn't a risky experiment. It's a road thousands walked before you.

I'm going to introduce you to Patricia, who took on her entire family and whose children are now her best argument. To Hadrián, who learned to read at nine—nine!—and now devours books. To whole communities built from nothing because somebody decided their children deserved better.

If the last chapter gave you the armor, this one gives you the certainty

that you've backed the right horse.

Encouragement and What Comes Next

5. Families Who Made It Work

Three years after taking my children out of school, I ran into the head of the school they would have gone to. It was awkward. She knew our decision and I knew she didn't approve of it. Then something I didn't expect happened: she asked after my children. Not sarcastically. She actually wanted to know.

I told her my eldest, who at seven was “behind” by school standards because he still didn't read fluently, was now ten and getting through four-hundred-page novels. That my youngest, who never sat in a math class, understands fractions because she cooks with me and doubles recipes. That both of them have friends, things they love, and projects that run for months because nobody tells them it's time to move on to the next subject.

The head nodded slowly and said something I've never forgotten: “I wish every child had that chance.”

This chapter isn't propaganda. It's evidence. These are the stories you need at two in the morning when you doubt. Real cases of ordinary families—not heroes, not teaching geniuses—who simply trusted that their children could do well outside the system. And they did.

In Part Two I told you *my* story: my road with Arjuna and Nitai, the Spanish learned with colored sticks, the areas we calculated to paint rooms, the way we handled ordinary school on our own terms. That was my own demonstration, in depth, of what this can look like.

Now I want you to meet other families. Some I've mentioned in passing—Patricia, and Marta and Julio with Hadrián—and now they get their own space. Because if I only tell you my experience, you could think it worked for him, my situation is different. You need to see it work for all kinds of families: mothers who took on relatives, fathers who built communities out of nothing, children who learned to read at nine and now can't be pulled away from a book.

Here's the proof. Not in theory. In real life, with real children, in imperfect families like yours and mine.

Families Who Teach at Home

Over the years we've heard plenty of stories from families who decided to teach at home. What comes through is the effort and the nerve of parents who fought for the right to choose, against legal and social pressure. What they show is that home can be a place where children learn more than academic content—they also learn how to be with people and how to handle themselves.

1. Patricia: taking on the whole family

Patricia is a mother I met at the *Crece en Libertad* gatherings. By then she'd been teaching her two children outside the system for three years. Her road wasn't easy.

“My family called me irresponsible,” she told me one afternoon while our children played in the park. “My mother actually cried when I said I was taking them out of school. She said, ‘You’re wrecking their future.’”

But Patricia had seen something in her children her family hadn't. Her eldest, Marcos, who was eight, came home from school the same way every day: bag on the floor, blank stare, silence. When she asked what he'd learned, he shrugged. “Nothing.”

“It wasn’t that he’d learned nothing,” Patricia says. “It was that nothing had /mattered/. He’d spent six hours following orders, filling in sheets, waiting for the bell. And something in him was going out.”

The break came when Marcos, who had always loved dinosaurs, came home crying because his teacher had taken away the paleontology book he was reading during math. “This isn’t dinosaur time,” she said. “It’s fractions time.”

Patricia decided that week.

The first months were chaos. Marcos was deschooling—the stretch where children need time to come down from school and remember that learning can be a pleasure. He spent weeks doing nothing productive by school standards. He built with LEGO. He read comics. He watched documentaries.

“My mother came to visit and found me at eleven in the morning with Marcos in his pajamas watching a BBC documentary about the Jurassic. She looked at me as though I’d lost my mind. ‘This is education?’ she asked me.”

But Patricia held. Three months later Marcos started asking questions. First about dinosaurs, then geology, then tectonic plates, then volcanoes. One interest pulled the next. Patricia joined the dots—found books, museums, amateur paleontologists.

At ten, Marcos wrote a twenty-page essay on the extinction of the dinosaurs that took in current theories about the asteroid impact, the geological evidence, and a critical look at the alternatives. He wrote it for pleasure. Nobody assigned it.

“My mother read that essay,” Patricia told me, smiling. “And for the first time in three years she said nothing critical. Only: ‘Marcos knows more about this than I know about my own degree.’”

Marcos is twelve now. He wants to be a paleontologist. Maybe he

will be, maybe he'll find something else. What matters is that he *loves* learning. The spark that was going out at school now burns.

And Patricia's family, the one that called her irresponsible, now asks her for advice.

2. The traveling family: the world as a classroom

I met Laura and Miguel at a homeschoolers' gathering in Barcelona. But they didn't live in Barcelona—they didn't live anywhere permanently. For five years they traveled Europe, Asia and Latin America with their three children, aged seven, ten and thirteen, and made the whole world their classroom.

"People always ask us, 'But how do they learn without school?'" Laura said. "And I answer, 'How could they /not/ learn, surrounded by all this?'"

In Thailand her children learned about Buddhism by visiting temples and talking to monks. In Peru they studied Inca history walking through Machu Picchu with a local guide who explained how the aqueducts were engineered. In Morocco they practiced math haggling in the souks—currency conversion, percentages, what money is actually worth in a given place.

"My eldest, Claudia, learned more about economics bargaining with sellers in Kathmandu than I learned in two years of secondary school," Miguel says. "She understood supply and demand, profit margins, what tourism does to a local economy—all of it hands-on."

But the most valuable part wasn't the academic content. It was what it did to how the children see the world.

"When we were in Vietnam, a local family invited us to dinner," Laura says. "They lived in a bamboo house with a dirt floor. We ate rice and vegetables sitting on the ground. My children played with the local children even though they had no language in common—gestures,

laughing, a ball they made out of something.”

That night Claudia asked her mother: “Why are they happy if they have so little?” It started long conversations about wealth, happiness and how differently other people see things—the sort no textbook teaches with the same weight.

The children picked up the basics of five languages, enough to get by, out of necessity. They learned geography not by memorizing capitals but by reading real maps, planning routes, working out time zones because they had to call family in Spain.

“And math? Science?” I asked.

“Khan Academy in the evenings, when we had wifi,” Miguel says. “An hour a day. And then they applied it constantly in real life—distances, converting Celsius to Fahrenheit, working out why the monsoon rains fall when they do in India.”

After five years they came back to Spain. The children folded into local activities, sports, homeschool groups. And something worth noting: they talk about Asia, Africa and Latin America not as far-off exotic places but as real places with real people they met.

“Claudia said to me not long ago, ‘Mum, on the television they say refugees are dangerous. But we met refugee families in Greece. They were like us—they only wanted their children safe,’” Laura says, with her eyes filling. “No school would have given her that.”

They traveled on very little—Couchsurfing, cheap hostels, cooking their own food. It wasn't luxury. It was a decision. And the result is three children with a view of the world, real feeling for other people, and an appetite for learning about cultures, languages and history.

What will they do as adults? They don't know. But they'll be citizens of the world and not only of one country.

3. Samuel: dyslexia without the label

Samuel's story reached me through his mother, Elena, on a home-schooling forum. Samuel was diagnosed with severe dyslexia at seven. The school recommended special education, speech therapy three times a week, and lowered academic expectations.

"They basically told us Samuel would never read fluently," Elena wrote. "That we'd have to accept his 'limitations.'"

Elena didn't accept it. Not because she denied the dyslexia—dyslexia is real—but because she refused the story of limitation. She took Samuel out of school and went looking for another way.

She found the Orton-Gillingham method, built for children with dyslexia. Thirty minutes every morning of structured work—multisensory phonics, cards, games with letters. The rest of the day Samuel learned with no pressure on him.

"I read aloud to him two hours a day," Elena says. "Adventure novels, science fiction, whatever he wanted. And while I read, he followed the words with his finger. I never made him read himself."

Something happened around the age of ten. Samuel started to read on his own—quietly, slowly, but *for pleasure*. Comics first, then graphic novels, then books with more text on the page.

"At twelve he was reading Harry Potter," Elena says. Not at the level of children his age, but with understanding and with pleasure. And this mattered more: he didn't hate reading. He didn't feel stupid or slow.

What made the difference wasn't only the method. It was the surroundings. At home Samuel wasn't the boy with learning difficulties. There were no comparisons. No red marks. No shame.

Samuel also had strengths school never counted. He was excellent at

visual math—geometry, patterns, building in three dimensions. With LEGO he made complicated structures without instructions. With strategy games he worked through hard logical problems.

“At school it was all reading and writing,” Elena says. “Samuel failed at what they measured, so he was a failure. At home we could see all of him—spatial, logical, physical. He was a whole child, not a label.”

At fourteen Samuel reads reasonably well. Writing is still hard—he uses spellcheckers and text-to-speech when he needs them. But he's learning programming, where spelling matters less, and 3D design, and he wants to study architecture.

“Would he have got there in school?” Elena asks. “Maybe. But not without deep damage. Not without years of feeling inferior, broken, incapable.”

The lesson isn't that homeschooling cures dyslexia. The lesson is that when you take away constant comparison, when you let a child work at his own speed, when you count more than one kind of intelligence, children do well. Including, especially, children with “learning difficulties.”

These are three stories. I could tell you thirty. Families in small city flats. Rural families with vegetable patches. Single mothers with two jobs. Couples with five children. Every one different in its details and identical underneath: when you trust that your child can learn, when you make a place built on respect and freedom, when you let curiosity lead—children learn. Not in spite of there being no school. Precisely because there isn't one.

What Our Children Teach Us

Learning doesn't only run one way. Parents teach, and they also learn from their children. Plenty of home-educating parents find their children have a curiosity and a set of abilities that take them by surprise. Through the

questions children ask, parents end up rethinking what they believed about school, and giving freedom and play their proper weight.

What parents describe is how children, with nothing in the way, come up with their own ways of learning. Moments that would have been routine turn into something real, where playing and exploring do the work. A child who started reading and writing on his own after a stretch of unstructured time shows what play can do. Both parent and child end up somewhere that curiosity and shared responsibility can grow, and where each person's own progress counts.

Learning Together: the Family as a School

Teaching at home puts the family at the center of learning. It recognizes that learning happens between people, and that everybody in the house both gives and gets. Sharing what you know and what you can do makes a place where people learn together. Ordinary things—cooking, gardening, a project everybody has a hand in—turn into the moments that count.

It also matters to build something with other families doing the same. Support networks let parents swap resources and ideas while the children are around other children. Families who meet up to do things together don't only get closer at home—the children learn to read each other and to work problems out side by side.

Children changing, everybody learning from everybody, and a community around it: those are the three legs of this. Learning isn't confined to a room or an hour. It runs through the day, and every house becomes a place where something is happening. Parents and children grow up together.

These stories will have given you some hope. Maybe they made your eyes sting. Patricia, Hadrián, all those families who made it work—they're the proof.

But now I have an uncomfortable question: what then?

Your child grows up in freedom. He does well, learns at his own pace, gets deep into what he loves. Good. But he doesn't live only in your house. He lives in a world where almost every other child goes to school. Where employers ask about qualifications. Where the school system carries on, grinding through one generation after another.

Does this stay inside your family? Or does it have to be bigger than that?

6. What Comes Next, and Your Part in It

Five years on. My son is twelve. I'm in the supermarket, in the queue. The neighbor who used to look at me with pity—the one who asked “and what about socialization?” in that falsely concerned voice—comes over.

“Listen,” he says, almost whispering. “My son is suffering at school. He doesn’t want to go. He cries every morning.” A long pause. “How... how did you start?”

There it is. The moment you realize this was never only about your family.

What a Different Future Might Look Like

Every family that chooses this is an act of resistance. Not violent, not political. Just human. We're saying: our children deserve better, and we're going to give it to them.

But here's the uncomfortable part: while we teach our children in freedom, millions of children are still stuck in a system that flattens them. Alternative education—unschooling, Montessori, Waldorf, homeschooling—offers models that work. That take the individual child seriously. That let children be children.

When does it stop being “alternative” and become normal?

Your Part in It

Conscious parenting starts with you. With being there when your child asks something. With thinking about why you react the way you do. With recognizing that your fears—about his future, about what people will say, about whether he'll “succeed”—are yours and not his.

Teaching a child to feel for other people isn't a technique. It's living in a way that shows him feelings matter, other people matter, and that being human is a strength and not a weakness.

But let's be honest: this is bigger than your family.

The neighbor in the supermarket asked me how to start. I gave him John Holt. I told him about the communities. I offered him a coffee so we could talk properly. Three months later he took his son out of school.

His son now has somebody to play with—mine. Two more families joined. There are five of us. Next year there'll be ten. Or twenty.

You don't have to start a movement. The movement is already there. You only have to join it. Put your story somewhere a desperate person at two in the morning will find it. Get to know other families, even one, so you aren't alone. Stand up for the right of families to choose, when the chance comes. Get other people to question what they assume, just by living your own way without apologizing for it.

Every conversation counts. Every family that joins multiplies what's possible. Every child raised in freedom becomes an adult who remembers that learning can be a pleasure.

The Question That Started It

Back to the beginning. To the morning my son asked: “Dad, why is the sky blue?”

If I'd said “I don't know” and gone back to my coffee, it would have been

one more question, forgotten in five minutes. If I'd given him the complete answer—Rayleigh scattering, short wavelengths, the atmosphere—he'd have memorized empty words.

Instead we sat down. We looked into it together. He led, I went along. Two hours later he understood not only why the sky is blue but something that matters far more: that his questions count. That learning is finding out, not reciting. That adults don't have all the answers, and that's fine.

That morning changed our life. Not because he learned about the visible spectrum. Because we both learned we could trust his curiosity.

He's twelve now. He still asks. And I still don't have all the answers.

But we keep looking into things together.

Your child will ask you something tomorrow. Something ordinary. The question matters less than what you do with it.

That moment—the instant you decide whether to give a quick answer or sit down and find out together—is where all of this starts.

You don't need a perfect plan. You don't need to know the theories. You don't need to be brave in front of the whole world.

You only need to choose, in that moment, to trust your child's curiosity.

The rest comes on its own.

Epilogue

Raising and teaching children in freedom isn't only a private choice. It's a push to change what we understand about learning and about childhood. Through this book we've gone over different ways of doing it, and kept coming back to natural learning, a child's independence, and the communities that hold families up.

Community is the part that carries you. Together, as families, we get stronger by swapping what we've lived and holding each other up. Every story shared reflects a shared commitment to changing how we think about raising and teaching children. We've run into real difficulties, from social criticism to resistance from school systems, and those difficulties are also where the argument for a more open and respectful education gets made.

Choosing to teach at home, or to do it some other unconventional way, is a statement of trust in what a particular child could become. The range of approaches matters: every family can find its own way across the whole spread of alternative education. Recognizing that range is good for all of us.

How a child feels matters as much as what he knows. Making a place where children feel safe and valued, where love and trust are built up, is what lets them grow. And while we're feeding curiosity, we also have to look at what we ourselves believe and how it shows up in what we do each day.

Every one of us can shift something. Looking ahead, picture a world where

this is the normal way. A future where families, teachers and communities work together, respect individual choices, and build places worth learning in.

This epilogue is a call to act. Let's make somewhere safe for our children, with love running through it. Let's turn criticism into conversation. Closing this book, let's carry the determination to change something.

The adventure goes on. Let's keep growing together and take the beauty of being free seriously. Let's be part of something that redefines what it means to teach with love.

Appendix: The Legal Basics

Before starting down this road it's natural to ask: is it legal to teach at home where I live? It's the most common question, and the one that produces the most fear. Legal fear can stop you before you take the first step.

The short answer: it depends where you are. But in most of the places where you'll be reading this, teaching at home is legal, or sits in a grey area that lets you get on with it.

Here's the basic picture by region. I'm not a lawyer and this isn't legal advice, but it's enough to know where to start and where to ask.

Spain: a grey area that lets you do it

In Spain, teaching at home sits in a legal gap. It's neither explicitly allowed nor explicitly banned. The constitution guarantees the right to an education, and the law requires schooling between six and sixteen—but “schooling” is read in different ways.

Thousands of families teach at home in Spain without trouble. Some get a visit from social services, but if the child is clearly learning and clearly well, serious legal consequences are unusual.

What to do:

- Join ALE, the Free Education Association, for current legal advice
- Keep a record of what your children are doing (portfolios, photographs, projects)

- Have your answers ready if social services asks
- Get to know local families already doing it—the community is the thing that helps

The fear against what actually happens:

Here's the truth you need to hear: the fear people carry is far bigger than what actually happens.

For parental rights to be removed in Spain, something serious has to be going on—domestic violence, drugs, severe neglect. Teaching at home, on its own, is not grounds for losing custody. Nowhere near.

What's the worst that can happen if it reaches a court? That a judge orders you to send your child to school. That's it. No enormous fines. No prison. Nobody takes your children. Only an order to enroll them. And getting that far is unlikely.

My own experience: some people who resented us reported us. The social workers came to the house. They went over everything. They talked to the children. They found them well looked after, happy, and learning. There was no problem.

But the complaints kept coming. I had to go and see the provincial prosecutor for minors, who threatened me with fines and legal consequences. It was unpleasant. It was stressful.

Do you know what happened? We moved to another province. And that was the end of it. Once we were outside that jurisdiction, the whole thing came to nothing. No fines. No court. Nothing.

The lesson: the system barks more than it bites. If your children are well—and they will be—the authorities have no real interest in chasing you. They have actual abuse and neglect to deal with. They aren't going to spend resources on families where the children are obviously thriving.

Latin America: it varies enormously

The situation changes sharply from country to country:

- **Mexico:** Legal and relatively straightforward. Thousands of families do it without real obstacles.
- **Argentina:** A grey area much like Spain. Families do it; the authorities generally don't intervene.
- **Chile:** Legal since 2018. Requires notifying the education ministry and annual assessments.
- **Colombia:** Legal. Requires validation through ICFES examinations.
- **Brazil:** Explicitly banned since 2018, by a contested Supreme Court decision.

What to do: Find the homeschooling groups for your particular country. Laws change, and local communities have the current information.

United States: the easiest place

The US is one of the friendliest countries for home education. It's legal in all fifty states, though each state has its own rules.

- **Texas, Alaska, Oklahoma:** Minimal regulation. No notification or assessment required.
- **California, New York:** Stricter. Notification, records, or affiliation with a supervised program.
- Organizations like **HSLDA** (Home School Legal Defense Association) provide legal defense if something comes up.

If you're in the US, look up your state's rules at hslda.org.

Canada: legal, varies by province

Every province has its own rules:

- **Ontario:** Very flexible. Informal notification only.
- **Alberta:** Registration and periodic assessments.
- **Quebec:** Stricter. The education plan has to be approved.

Contact provincial homeschooling groups for specifics.

Europe: from banned to free

- **United Kingdom:** Legal and fairly free. You only have to notify if the child was already enrolled.
- **France:** Legal, with annual inspections since recent reforms.
- **Germany: Banned.** Germany has the strictest laws in Europe. Families who persist can face heavy fines or lose custody. Many German families move to a neighboring country in order to teach at home.
- **Netherlands, Belgium, Sweden:** Legal, with notification and supervision requirements.
- **Norway:** Banned except in unusual circumstances, such as distance from a school.

The key point: If you live somewhere it's banned or very difficult, look into flexible-schooling arrangements or free schools that respect how you want to do it.

What if my country isn't listed?

Look for:

1. Social media groups: "Homeschooling [your country]"
2. Local alternative-education organizations
3. Online forums on respectful parenting

You'll nearly always find families already doing it who can point you the right way.

The Most Important Thing Here

Don't let legal fear stop you.

In most places, thousands of families teach at home without trouble. Legal intervention is rare and usually follows an accusation of neglect, which has nothing to do with home education itself.

If a child is clearly learning, around other people, and happy, the authorities rarely step in, even in the legal grey areas.

Key Legal Resources

- **HSLDA** (*hsllda.org*): Legal defense in the US and international resources
- **ALE Spain** (*educacionlibre.org*): The Spanish association, with legal advice
- **Local groups**: Always your best source of current information

The law matters. But don't let it be the thing that stops you giving your child the education he deserves. Find out where you stand, get to know other families, keep a record of what your children are doing—and trust that thousands of families crossed this water before you and got to the other side.

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Online Resources:

1. ALE (Asociación para la Educación Libre), Spain. www.ale.org
2. Homeschooling en Acción. Support group for home-educating families. www.homeschoolingenaccion.com
3. KIDDIFY. Platform for young people to share what they know. www.kiddify.com

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About the Author

Juan Manuel Ferrera Díaz is a father, a self-taught man, and an advocate of alternative education. With no formal higher education, he is himself an example of what this book argues: the learning that goes deepest comes out of real need and real curiosity, not an imposed curriculum.

Over his life he has taught himself programming, design, educational philosophy, and whatever else his projects and interests demanded—not because a course required it but because life did. That has given him an unusual grasp of how self-directed learning actually works.

His commitment to raising children in freedom comes out of being a father and of finding out first-hand that qualifications are not the same thing as knowledge or ability. This book is the result of years of self-directed research, thinking, and the practical business of raising his own children outside the school system.

If this book was useful to you, pass it on to another family who might need it. And if you want to tell me what you made of it, write to me—I read everything.

